

Post-vaccination rebounds in the SIR model

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1 Theoretical honeymoon period in the SEIR model

We will consider how reductions in vaccination rates can lead to rebounds in disease prevalence in a SEIR (Susceptible, Exposed, Infected, Recovered) model. In particular, we will focus on the post-vaccination “honeymoon”, or how long it takes for the disease to rebound after vaccination rates start declining.

To begin, we will consider the simplest case where (a) a population has been under the vaccination regime for sufficiently long period of time to be at equilibrium, and (b) that the pathogen is locally extinct. Let v_0 be the vaccination rate during the period of herd immunity, and let v be the vaccination rate after the decline begins.

In the SEIR model, we know there are two possible equilibria:

1. disease-free equilibrium, where $S^* = v_0$
2. endemic equilibrium, where $S^* = \frac{1}{\beta}(\mu + \gamma + \frac{\mu v(\mu + \gamma)}{\sigma})$

Here, we are only considering the first case where a population is above the herd immunity threshold, $1/R_0$, because otherwise there is no honeymoon period. We are interested in the duration of the honeymoon period, which we hypothesize will depend on a number of factors including the R_0 of the pathogen, the equilibrium number of susceptibles S^* , the birth rate μ , the new vaccination coverage v under decline, and the timing of importations. Because we cannot control the timing of importations, we ignore this piece and define the honeymoon period as the time it takes for $R_e = 1/R_0 * S > 1$. In other words, the time it takes for R_e to cross 1 is a lower bound on the honeymoon period, where any importation after this point will start an outbreak.

We can calculate analytically the time it takes for R_e to cross 1, under assumptions of local extinction (i.e., $I = 0$) and a constant vaccination rate, v . In this case, we have a differential equation for the number of susceptibles, S , which we can solve using the following steps:

$$\frac{dS}{dt} = \mu(1 - v) - \mu S \quad (1)$$

$$e^{\mu t} \left(\frac{dS}{dt} + \mu S \right) = e^{\mu t} \mu(1 - v) \quad (2)$$

$$\int e^{\mu t} \left(\frac{dS}{dt} + \mu S \right) dt = \int e^{\mu t} \mu(1 - v) dt \quad (3)$$

$$\int e^{\mu t} \frac{dS}{dt} + e^{\mu t} \mu S dt = \int e^{\mu t} \mu(1 - v) dt \quad (4)$$

$$e^{\mu t} S = (1 - v)e^{\mu t} + C \quad (5)$$

$$S(t) = (1 - v) + Ce^{-\mu t} \quad (6)$$

and solving $S(0)$ gives us $C = S_0 - (1 - v)$. Thus, we have:

$$S(t) = (1 - v) + (S_0 - (1 - v))e^{-\mu t}$$

We can find the time t it takes for $R_e = 1/R_0 * S(t) > 1$, which yields

$$t = \frac{-1}{\mu} \log \left(\frac{1/R_0 - (1 - v)}{S_0 - (1 - v)} \right)$$

We can also rewrite this equation to show us the relationship between prior vaccination coverage and new vaccination coverage, that will yield equivalent honeymoon periods. When vaccination rates are above the herd immunity threshold, $S_0 = v_0$ the pre-drop vaccination coverage, so

$$t = \frac{-1}{\mu} \log \left(\frac{1/R_0 - (1 - v)}{v_0 - (1 - v)} \right) \quad (7)$$

$$v_0 = v - e^{-\mu t} \left(1/R_0 - (1 - v) \right) \quad (8)$$

$$v_0 = e^{-\mu t} (1 - 1/R_0) + (1 + e^{-\mu t})v \quad (9)$$

2 Unity beta and the effect of age structure

Age structured dynamics are known to be important for a range of infectious disease, and we will consider how this affects the honeymoon period. In particular, we will use a theoretical quantity called “unity beta” to explore these effects.

First we outline the unity beta calculation. Consider an age-structured transmission process that is governed by heterogeneous contacts between age groups, where the number of new infections in the age structured model is

$$\text{age-structured infections} = \frac{\beta}{N} \sum_{i=1}^n \sum_{j=1}^n \theta_{i,j} S_i I_j \quad (10)$$

$$= \frac{\beta}{kN} \sum_{i=1}^n \sum_{j=1}^n \theta_{i,j} S_i I_j \quad (11)$$

where $\theta_{i,j}$ is the contact rate between age groups i and j and k is the quantity called “unity beta” (i.e., the scalar on β such that the number of new infections in the age-structured model is equal to the number of new infections in a non-age-structured model). Then,

$$k = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^n \sum_{j=1}^n \theta_{i,j} S_i I_j}{\sum_{i=1}^n S_i \sum_{j=1}^n I_j}$$

where $1/k$ is the multiplier on the transmission rate. Thus, if $1/k > 1$ then $\lambda_{\text{hom}} > \lambda_{\text{het}}$ and the age-structured dynamics are slow relative to the homogenous dynamics.

However, in the analysis, we do something slightly different. For the same transmission rate, different WAIFW matrices can yield different numbers of infections at equilibrium. Thus, we calculated a scalar c such that the number of infections at equilibrium in the age-structured model is equal to the number of infections in the non-age-structured model (i.e., $\beta_{\text{hom}} = c\beta_{\text{het}}$).

If we calculate unity beta directly in this case, we are getting the transmission scalar to equate with a homogeneous model *with the same transmission rate*, $c\beta_{\text{het}}$. But we are actually interested in finding the transmission scalar to equate with a homogeneous model *with the same number of infections at equilibrium*, β_{hom} . Thus, we have to adjust unity beta to account for the difference in transmission rate and the difference in the total number of susceptible individuals at equilibrium (also note, we find the scalar numerically, so there will be slight differences in number of infections as well).

Thus, we have

$$\text{age-structured infections} = \frac{\beta c}{N} \sum_{i=1}^n \sum_{j=1}^n \theta_{i,j}^{\text{het}} S_i^{\text{het}} I_j^{\text{het}} \quad (12)$$

$$\text{homogenous infections} = \frac{\beta}{N} \sum_{i=1}^n \sum_{j=1}^n \theta_{i,j}^{\text{hom}} S_i^{\text{hom}} I_j^{\text{hom}} \quad (13)$$

WLOG, let $\theta_{i,j}^{\text{hom}} = 1$ for all i, j . We can then equate these two quantities with unity beta scalar k :

$$\frac{\beta}{N} \sum_{i=1}^n \sum_{j=1}^n S_i^{\text{hom}} I_j^{\text{hom}} = k \frac{\beta c}{N} \sum_{i=1}^n \sum_{j=1}^n \theta_{i,j}^{\text{het}} S_i^{\text{het}} I_j^{\text{het}} \quad (14)$$

where

$$k = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^n S_i^{\text{hom}} \sum_{j=1}^n I_j^{\text{hom}}}{c \sum_{i=1}^n \sum_{j=1}^n \theta_{i,j}^{\text{het}} S_i^{\text{het}} I_j^{\text{het}}} \quad (15)$$

This is a scaled ratio of the number of new infections in the homogenous model to the number of new infections in the age-structured model. Interpretation is the same as the unity beta above, and showing on the log scale allows for equal visual comparison between n-fold reductions and increases in transmission rate.